

Hah Definition

HD is here. Well, in theory. Now what?

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No doubt you're quite familiar with all the HD-oriented blathering we've done in the past few months. Now that you can ride the cutting edge of display technology for as little (?) as, and perhaps less than, Rs 40,000, the world of high-definition movies, gaming and television is your oyster. Just one problem, though.

Nothing's On

In a typical case of hardware overtaking software, there's a terrifying lack of content for us to watch on our shiny new HD screens. Worse, because the standard-definition content you're watching is lower than your HDTV's native resolution, it looks *awful*—much more so than on your old CRT TV. Before we even bother wondering about the future of HD, we must worry about the future of HD content. At the end of 2006, 8.5 million households in Japan were satisfying themselves with a daily dose of HD content. Together, American and Japanese households make up 91 per cent of the world's HDTV-enabled population. Meanwhile, we must fester in our jealousy—apart from the minority that subscribes to Direct-to-home (DTH) and Conditional Access System (CAS) for television, nobody experiences digital TV; HD content is but a dream. If you consider the world outside the US and Japan, it's quite clear we're not alone in our deprivation, and we can take some comfort in that fact. But whither content?

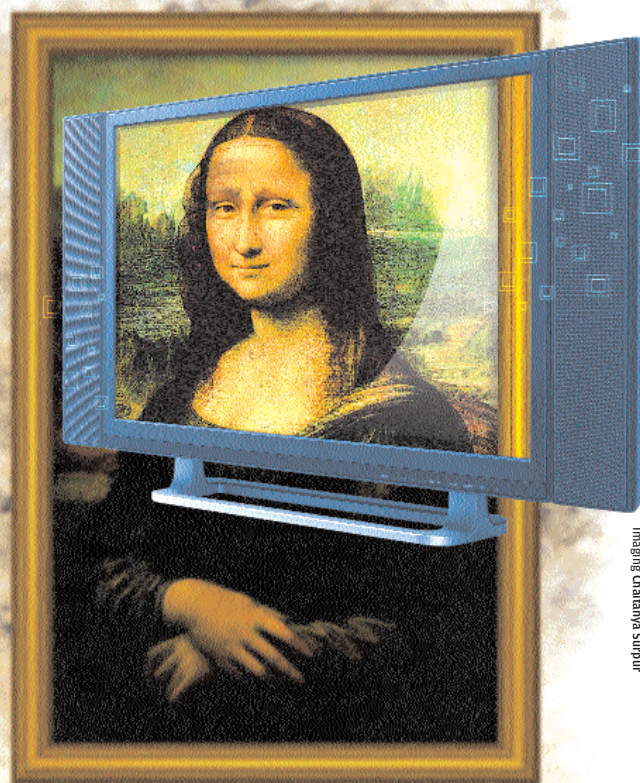
When we spoke to IOL Broadband about... er... broadband earlier this year, we were treated to claims of HDTV services that will be available in "a few days." It's been quite a few days, and HDTV is still just an item under "Services" on their Web site. Not that they are to blame—nobody's making HD content for television! It's the chicken-and-egg story all over again...

We bitch aplenty now, but the transition to HD is as inevitable as the transition from black-and-white to colour television—slow and lumbering though it might be. And then, perhaps within the decade itself, HD will become passé.

Beyond Just HD

While we gush over the gorgeous resolution of 1920 x 1080 (1080p) that true HD offers, Japan's NHK (Nippon Hoso Kyokai, or the Japan Broadcasting Corporation) has been testing a new format called Super Hi-vision, or Ultra High Definition TV (UHDTV), which offers sixteen times the pixel resolution—an eye-popping 7680 x 4320 (4320p)!

Visually, there's little here in the way of enhanced experiences, though—it's effectively the same old HD, just really, really big. What does make a difference is the audio. Where we rejoice with 7.1 channels, viewers of UHD content will be treated to glorious 22.2-channel audio—24



Imaging: Chaitanya Surpur

speakers, arranged in three layers: ten at ear level, nine above and five below.

Even NHK admits that the technology is experimental and it'll most likely be a decade, perhaps longer, before we see such resolutions in auditoriums, and much longer for living rooms. Firstly, because... well, think about it: at 2000p, movies are crisp and impeccable on large movie screens, and even that's a novelty; it'll be a long while before HD becomes "boring old standard definition." Secondly, there's the matter of storage. Each minute of uncompressed UHD video takes up a 194 GB, so a two-hour movie will occupy a gargantuan 25 terabytes! Even the best compression will result in a movie that's a couple of terabytes in size; where are we going to put it all?

That, incidentally, is the question everyone's asking.

Blu-ray vs. HD-DVD vs. EVD vs. Who?

We all know of the infinitely nauseating Blu-ray vs. HD-DVD wars—while they've haunted our consciousness for so many years, they're *still* not mainstream, leaving ample time for people to come up with alternatives that may just take the lead from behind...

Our underdog in this race is the Enhanced Versatile Disc (EVD)—developed and supported by an alliance of Chinese consumer electronics manufacturers, the EVD isn't a new disc format, per se—it's based on the same old red-laser technology used in today's DVD players. It just uses a new, proprietary compression method to squeeze two hours of high-definition video on to a 9 GB dual-layer DVD. This, however, doesn't mean that EVDs will work on your old DVD drive or player, mind you—money will need to flow out of your pockets,